

ORECCHIETTE

Pasta, Missy Robbins

REST

1 to 2 hours at room temperature

DETAILS

- Dough: semolina-dough
- Region: Mostly Puglia; also Calabria, Basilicata, Molise, reaching north into Abruzzo

METHOD

1. Make semolina dough. Dust a wooden board with a little 00 flour. Line a sheet pan with parchment, then dust the parchment with semolina.
2. Quarter the dough. Work one piece and keep the rest under plastic wrap or a towel.
3. Press the piece into a thick rope by hand. Set the fingertips of both hands together at its midpoint, then roll back and forth while walking your hands apart toward the ends.
4. Keep rolling under light pressure until the rope is about 1/2 inch across, roughly as thick as a Sharpie, and about 18 inches long. Cut it in half and roll the halves separately if it gets too long to handle.
5. Cut the rope into 1/2-inch lengths with a knife or bench scraper. Cut them longer while you are learning, since bigger pieces are easier to shape. Cover the pieces you are not shaping.
6. Hold a butter knife serrated-edge-down with its tip against the edge of a piece at a 30-degree angle, then drag the dough toward you across the board. Lean into it. Semolina dough takes real pressure, and you want the middle of the shape thin. Stopping here gives you a cavatello.
7. Use your first two fingers to pull the dough off the knife and up over your thumb, turning it inside out while your thumb pushes up to form a dome. Work through the rest of the cut pieces.
8. Lay the finished pasta on the sheet pan in a single layer.
9. Repeat from step 3 with the remaining dough.
10. Dry 1 to 2 hours at room temperature, until the pasta stiffens slightly and holds its shape when handled.
11. To hold it, wrap the pan in plastic and refrigerate up to 24 hours.

SHAPING



NOTES

Dimensions run 1/2-inch rope, about 18 inches long, cut into 1/2-inch pieces. Finished size ranges from a quarter down to a dime, smallest around Bari.

The tool is the serrated edge of an ordinary butter knife. There are two gestures: the drag, then the flip off the knife tip onto the thumb. The flip is what makes an orecchietta instead of a cavatello, and it is the hardest gesture in the book to get right. Expect hundreds of edible failures first.

Keep the board only lightly floured. Too much flour kills the friction and the drag will not take.

Traditionally a water dough built on semolina, durum wheat flour, grano arso, or a blend of two of the three.

Refrigerator limit is 24 hours.

Sauced with tomato and ricotta salata, or with broccoli rabe cooked down with garlic and anchovy.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____

RATING ____ / 5

OVEN ADJ. _____

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